



AFTER

Lee's decision to fight at Sharpsburg (see [Holding the sunken road](#)), rather than withdraw across the Potomac into Virginia, showed a confidence in his troops' superior ability.



GEORGE BRINTON McCLELLAN

LEE RALLIES

Although Lee was buoyed by news of Jackson's success at Harpers Ferry, he was also unwilling to accept that his **Maryland campaign had failed**. McClellan, meanwhile, proceeded with his habitual caution. On September 15, his Army of the Potomac had begun arriving at Antietam Creek, but it **left Lee undisturbed** on the opposite bank. The next day, McClellan had some 60,000 men facing 25,000 Confederates. By September 17, he was ready, but **Lee had amassed most of his men**, so the chance of a decisive Union victory was missed.